

Program Plan

The Podcast Push Brunch Club: A Postsecondary Holistic Wellness Effort

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Introduction

The outreach librarians at James University's (JU) Sawyer Library (SL) are committed to reducing gaps in access to information and increasing community connections amongst students, staff, and other university stakeholders. Toward that end, we have been studying recently published, peer-reviewed research on the correlations between holistic wellness programming, academic success, and retention rates. Patterns in student behavior, more explicitly the tendency of students to forgo community involvement and strictly focus on their studies, have been observed as an element contributing to high rates of attrition (Reno, 2017). In anticipation of this pattern persisting, SL employees have been working to develop new programming to address this underserved population.

The Podcast Push Brunch Club (PPBC) program, as detailed below, is intended to attract students who may be experiencing academic overwhelm. It encourages them to take biweekly brain breaks, connects them with other students who may share similar interests, and helps them find a sense of belonging in the greater JU community they may not yet have found in their respective degree programs. By addressing not only students' academic needs, but also their extracurricular individual interests, SL hopes to have a positive impact on student well-being, and, in addition, JU's retention rates.

Overview Of Special Population Group

In 2020, only 49.1% of first-time postsecondary students in the United States graduated within four years of entry to an undergraduate bachelor's degree program (National Center for Education Statistics, 2024). During the spring of 2016, that same initial four-year undergraduate cohort self-reported that 42.9% of students experienced a "more than average" level of stress in the previous 12 months. An additional 11.1% were experiencing "tremendous stress" in the preceding 12 months (American College Health Association, 2016). When taken together, 54% of students who began their undergraduate careers in 2016 experienced high levels of stress.

ACHA's Spring 2016 health survey asked the same cohort if they had received information on the topic of stress reduction from their respective institutions; 63.6% answered yes. They were also asked if they were interested in receiving information on the topic of stress reduction from their institutions and 73.1% answered in the affirmative (ACHA, 2016). In considering the correlation between undergraduate stress levels and undergraduate interest in stress reduction, we identify a perceived gap in access to tangible stress reduction strategies. That same gap, approximately 10%, is mirrored in retention rate improvement studies. One specific study, performed at Elizabeth City State University in North Carolina, found that when the university shifted their mission and approach from an academic goals perspective to a more holistic, student-focused tactic, and began to "tackle the roadblocks that impede student success," their retention rate increase was 10% more than that of their sister institutions (Oliveira, 2017).

Many other successful examples of similar studies have been found in academic literature. These scholarly endeavors prove useful by forcing us to ask ourselves if how we have historically measured learning is modernly applicable. In processing this information, it seems clear that grades are not the only indicator of academic success. Therefore, we should focus a certain percentage of our outreach efforts on retaining students via programming that does not specifically address their academic goals.

Needs Assessment

A recent systematic review of over 6,000 articles about postsecondary perceptions of stress found that "elevated stress among tertiary students is positively associated with increased symptoms of physical illness, deteriorated mental health outcomes, poor sleep hygiene, increased substance abuse (e.g., alcohol, nicotine, and illicit drugs), being physically inactive, decreased life satisfaction scores, and reduced social engagement" (Lisnyj et al., 2023). For this library-initiated program, we will focus primarily on providing more opportunity for positive social engagement. We will explain below in further

detail how the podcast listening routines of students may also provide vicarious reinforcement of, or increased opportunity for, physical activity and life satisfaction.

To assess student needs in areas related to the library's influence on social engagement, subject matter interest, and listening preferences, the pre-program Baseline Survey (see Appendix A) will be circulated following administrative approval. Some initial assessment has revealed that a small group of interested students would prefer to start this program via Instagram. The survey aims to reveal: current rates of participation in social programming; baseline impressions of feelings of social connectedness; baseline perceptions of stress, burnout, overwhelm, and wanting to dropout; and initial interest in the PPBC program and its perceived usefulness. Furthermore, the survey is intended to unveil ideas that may prove useful in editing this draft of the program design to better fit the needs of JU students specifically.

Program Details

During the early stages of this program, we thought about aspects of student life that make elevated stress the new normal. We also considered the learning styles of current students and how many of them use podcasts as information resources. Historically though, recreational reading collections fulfilled that role and flourished in academic libraries. Midway through the 1900s those collections began to fall out of favor. In many institutions, recreational reading collections remained but were not well circulated due to shifting attitudes on what *should* be read (Brookbank et al., 2018). This posture toward a strict curricular focus along with the elimination of time dedicated to pleasurable pastimes stood out as a factor in the myriad causes of undue stress for students. Thus, helping students set aside time for non-academic learning in a community of podcast listeners became the goal.

The expectation for constant studiousness is exacerbated by the esoteric nature of the reading materials in many libraries. These materials can be a barrier for some students and, as such, it would be practical to incorporate popular books as a steppingstone for students to warm gradually to more

weighty texts (Blick, 2015). However, anyone who has been a tertiary student or has worked with tertiary students in the last couple decades knows that they tend to balk at the idea of reading more than what is assigned in their courses. Considering the dichotomy between the benefits of reading for pleasure and students' willingness, or lack thereof, to take on additional reading, the outreach librarians at SL designed the PPBC program to blend the knowledge found on podcasts with the attractiveness of social relevance.

The PPBC program will be held twice monthly, with each session discussing a different podcast episode that has been pushed into first place by popular vote via an ongoing social media campaign hosted by SL's Instagram page. JU students who have Instagram accounts will cast a vote for their favorite podcast episode in the two weeks preceding each in-person meeting. If students show interest but do not currently have access to social media accounts or do not wish to join Instagram, they will be encouraged to participate via paper at the SL reference desks or by emailing an outreach librarian. Marketing posters (see Appendix B) will be produced and posted on campus bulletin boards and flyers will be circulated to instructors.

The PPBC program is a more modern, more inclusive, more accessible take on a book club where, rather than having students read more, they may participate by simply listening to the featured podcast episode. Additionally, they will be encouraged to play any games the podcast episode touched on, watch the film the podcast guest directed, watch the comedy special the podcast guest spoke about, listen to a song on the podcasts guest's album, or, if they are so inclined, read any amount of the book the podcast guest wrote, etc. Given the varied nature of the millions of podcasts available, this list of supplementary activities is not exhaustive. Each meeting will be tailored to the content of the podcast episode. Following each vote, the outreach librarians would announce the winning episode via Instagram and urge any interested students who have not heard it to listen and join the fun! Any participants who

voted via paper will receive an email announcing the winning episode and outlining the brunch meeting space and time.

In addition to preparing for the discussion portion of each meeting, other planning will be necessary. Brunch will be offered in a library meeting space. Pastries, fruit, coffee, and juice will be made available for students and staff to take part in together. The amount of food purchased will be based on RSVPs. Prior to each meeting of the PPBC, outreach librarians will be designing talking points for each brunch session discussion around the featured episode. However, we anticipate that conversation will unfold naturally and many of these talking points may not be needed. This organic approach will hopefully result in freedom of thought in a constructive environment. Librarians will take care to keep conversation respectful and will model acknowledging differing perspectives, thereby encouraging diversity of thought. It is our hope that this will attract and reenergize students who may not typically participate in the library's social programs.

Using the Universal Design for Learning framework, which promotes providing multiple means of engagement, representation, as well as action and expression, this program has the potential to create opportunities for the sharing of new ideas for folks with differing motivations, perceptions, and styles of self-expression (Center for Applied Special Technology, 2018). The outreach librarians' intent is to have this program utilize the values of diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility to guide students in thought provoking discussion. This would boost their mood, provide an opportunity for connection, and prove to be a more relaxing environment than a classroom setting. Researchers believe that this kind of thoughtful attention to "quick break[s] and socializing" along with a variety of extracurricular topics being covered is a worthwhile endeavor in terms of reducing academic stress (Ramsey & Aagard, 2018).

The practicability of the design of the PPBC program is supported by the analysis of patterns in podcast and audiobook listening practices of adults, ages 18 to 19 years old, observed by Wallin (2022).

This study provided a framework for user habits that details when, how, and to what end audiobooks and podcasts are used. The outreach librarians at SL utilized the author's findings to design a marketing strategy for this program which includes encouraging students who may not have listened to that week's pushed podcast to do so during walking commutes, workouts, unwinding, pre-sleep routines, etc. (Wallin, 2022). In addition to being an inclusive effort, we believe the design of the PPBC will support healthy habits and overall well-being.

Program Assessment

While reading articles on the assessment of holistic support mechanisms, we came across topics such as: viewing students as partners in retention efforts (Lierman, 2022), campus-wide collaborations led by library outreach professionals (Mathuews & Lewis, 2017), the development of positive student attachments to library spaces (ODonnell & Anderson, 2022), and the significance of social capital in informal relationships between students in library spaces (Ramsey, 2016). These evaluations led the librarians here at SL to believe that more holistic programming like the PPBC will benefit the students at JU. We plan to perform periodic summative surveys (see Appendix C) capturing student perceptions of the outcomes of the PPBC series. The results of these surveys will be analyzed, used to modify future sessions, and shared with administrative staff to track the progress of the program.

Budget Implications

The library's outreach budget will be used to provide brunch items as well as compostable utensils, napkins, cups, and small plates from the local warehouse club retail store. If the program experiences initial success and students show continued interest, the outreach librarians will work with campus cafeteria personnel to discuss the possibility of utilizing less wasteful, more sustainable dishware to support the environment and to improve the overall economic viability of campus resources.

We expect to spend an average of about \$2.00 to \$4.00 per student on food. Bulk coffee is about \$1.25 per person, a donut is \$1.00, bulk muffins are .75 cents apiece, and a serving of bulk juice is about \$1.00. The per person cost of bulk disposable and compostable utensils, plates, cups, and napkins is approximately .25 cents. Marketing will primarily be digital, but we will be printing 20 color posters to post on the various bulletin boards located across campus and 100 color flyers for instructors to post in classrooms. Poster printing is about \$2.00 per copy and flyer printing is \$1.00 per copy at Robert's Printing on the Square, which would be a total printing cost of \$140.00. There may be sporadic costs associated with the purchase of additional episode-related material purchases such as interlibrary loan fees for acquiring several copies of a movie reviewed in a podcast episode. However, materials like boardgames may already be available in the library.

Conclusion

Asking JU students to read for pleasure and attend another traditional book club did not seem like a strategy that would have a measurable positive impact in the current academic atmosphere. However, the PPBC is just one example of how other, more holistic, student focused success strategies might be implemented to address well-being and retention. By finding a sense of belonging in group activities, students are better equipped to navigate the range of emotions they might feel at different stages of their individual academic journeys. The quality of student life improves as students engage in collaborative learning environments (ODonnell & Anderson, 2022). It is our intention that participants of the PPBC meetings will activate, develop, and strengthen what is arguably the best part of each of us; our ability to look outward and empathize with stories, experiences, and thoughts that are not our own. Though it may seem like a circuitous route to success, this holistic program will address student burnout and improve retention rates. The outreach librarians at JU hope this program improves the lives of the students and encourages further participation in library services.

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Appendix A

Baseline Survey

Section 1

1. Are you currently a James University (JU) student participating in an undergraduate degree program? Yes/No
2. Do you participate in any of the Sawyer Library's (SL) community programs/activities? Yes/No
3. If you do attend any of the library programs, do the programs help you feel connected to the campus community? Yes/No
4. If you do not participate in your library's programs, please briefly explain why. Short Response.
5. While you've attended JU, have you ever experienced:
 - burnout
 - stress
 - overwhelm
 - wanting to dropout
 - none of the above
6. If you have experienced burnout, stress, overwhelm, or wanting to dropout, do you think attending more social events would help reduce those feelings? Yes/No/Maybe

Section 2

Podcast Push Brunch Club (PPBC) program: SL is planning a new social program called "The Podcast Push Brunch Club". The goal of the program is to have JU students vote every two weeks on their favorite podcast and associated podcast episode. Following this biweekly vote, students would be invited to attend a free brunch (pastries, fruit, coffee, juice) in a library meeting space to participate in a discussion about the podcast episode that garnered the highest number of votes in the previous week.

7. Would you participate in the PPBC program as described above? Yes/No/Maybe
8. If yes or maybe, what social media platform would you like to use to vote for your favorite podcast/podcast episode? Please list only one.
9. What day of the week would you like the free brunch and discussion to take place on?
Sunday/Saturday
10. What time of day would you like the brunch and discussion to be offered? Multiple choice,
hourly options from 10:00 AM through 2:00 PM
11. Would you stay for the discussion portion or would you get food and leave? Multiple choice options:
 - I would stay for the discussion but only if my podcast episode won
 - I would stay for the discussion regardless of whether my podcast episode won
 - I would get food and leave
 - Other: _____
12. How many hours per week do you currently listen to podcasts? Multiple choice options:
 - 0
 - 1-2
 - 3-4
 - 5-6
 - 7+
13. Do you have any ideas about what would make this kind of program more inviting, more inclusive, more interesting, or more fun? If so, please share! Long response.

Appendix B

**FIRST EPISODE:
SATURDAY,
MARCH 9TH
PAULY SURE
MEETING ROOM
10 AM - 11 AM**



Sawyer Library presents:

THE PODCAST PUSH

Follow us on Instagram! Post your favorite recent podcast episode! We'll announce the winner! Scan the QR code to RSVP for brunch, activities, and conversation!

Any questions? Please contact:
sawyer_outreach_librarian@ju.edu



@sawyerlibrary 

Brain Breaks at Sawyer Library: The Podcast Push Brunch Club



Why are non-academic conversations important on campus?

The burnout and overwhelm that we feel as working professionals is often mitigated by the time we take away from our work to bond with others in our community. Did you know that this dynamic holds true for students as well?

University faculty have a direct impact on whether or not students graduate. Committing time to reducing stress levels experienced by students will have a positive influence on their well-being, their academic achievement, and on retention rates!

Connecting students who may share similar interests but come from differing backgrounds can help them find a sense of belonging in a new environment. Inviting them to the library for casual conversation with their peers can also promote diversity of thought and inclusion.

Would you like to start a Brain Breaks Program?

The Podcast Push Brunch Club (PPBC) program focuses on allowing students to select the topic of conversation via mini social media campaigns. Sawyer Library has found that Instagram works well currently but shifting social media preferences should be considered.

How does the PPBC work?

- Social media posts asking students to vote for their favorite podcast episode
- Additional voting at reference desks or via email
- Library-hosted meetings for casual conversation about the winning episode
- Pastry, coffee, juice, and brunch provided
- Planned talking points for breaks in conversation
- Digital and print marketing materials
- Librarians model conversation techniques that welcome diversity
- Creative provision of episode-specific materials

How to encourage diversity in attendance:

Making sure the program doesn't begin to feel stagnant or repetitive can be challenging but we have a few tried and true suggestions for you!

- Play games or do social quizzes the podcast episode touched on
- Invite students to watch the films or documentaries the podcast guest directed or starred in
- Ask students to listen to songs from the podcast guest's EPs or albums
- Invite students to watch the comedy special the podcast guest performed
- Do not require students to read books that podcast guests or hosts wrote but do offer the borrowing of those books
- Invite students to inquire if they would like to know more about any topics discussed on podcast episodes or during brunch meetings

We hope this information helps you get started! Feel free to contact our outreach department librarians with any questions at:

sawyer_outreach_librarian@ju.edu



@sawyerlibrary

Appendix C

Summative Survey

Section 1

1. Are you currently a James University (JU) student participating in an undergraduate degree program? Yes/No
2. Did you participate in the Sawyer Library's (SL) Podcast Push Brunch Club (PPBC) program?
Yes/No
3. If yes, did the PPBC program help you feel connected to the campus community? Yes/No
4. If it did not help you feel connected, please briefly explain why. Short response.
5. While you've attended JU, have you ever experienced:
 - burnout
 - stress
 - overwhelm
 - wanting to dropout
 - none of the above
6. If you have experienced burnout, stress, overwhelm, or wanting to dropout, did the PPBC program reduce those feelings in your perception? Yes/No/Maybe

Section 2

7. Did you enjoy participating in the PPBC program on _____ date? Yes/No
8. Was the use of Instagram as a voting platform easy, accessible, and enjoyable? Yes/No
9. Would the day of the week the meeting was held work for you again in the future?
Yes/No/Maybe
10. Would the time of day the meeting was held work for you again in the future? Yes/No/Maybe

11. Did you stay for the entirety of the meeting? Yes/No
12. Did you enjoy the brunch offerings (food & drink)? Yes/No
13. Did you, or do you plan to, invite any of your friends to the next PPBC meeting? Yes/No/Maybe
14. If you do not plan to invite a friend, please briefly explain why. Short response.
15. Do you have any ideas about what would make this program more inviting, more inclusive, more interesting, or more fun? If so, please share! Long response.